Chapter 30

Humane Policing:
Reforming Police Training through Soft Skills

AFTER DOING HER GRADUATION AND WHILE WAITING FOR ADMISSION to the university for joining a post-graduation course, there was a three-month waiting period. Kiran, instead of resting it out, cycled down to a good school located about 10 km away from her house at Amritsar and offered to teach nursery rhymes to the tiny tots. Her offer was accepted. She made the kids sing the rhymes along with her and made the activity playful and enjoyable. She then went on to pursue her post-graduation at the Punjab University, Chandigarh. Even before the announcement of the results, Kiran was offered a lecturer's job in a women's college by virtue of her being a topper during her graduation. She taught political science to undergraduate classes and became a student after the classes.

About 28 years later, in 1999, she again got an opportunity to prove her teaching skills: she became a trainer for men and women who were to join the Delhi Police force. She not only planned and supervised their training, but also, more importantly, this time meditated along with them, adding a new dimension to police training. Kiran had indeed come a long, long way, as she neared 30 years in the service.

Kiran conducted her training assignment in the Police Training College for Delhi Police. It was the first time that a senior police officer of the rank of joint commissioner (equivalent to inspector general) started to directly supervise training. The Police Training College was located at a place called Jharoda Kalan, which was more than 45 kilometres away from her house. She commuted daily, using the travelling time gainfully: she read newspapers or magazines and also cleared office work (in the form of pending files). Monitoring the quality of training, getting feedback from the students and coordinating with the staff were her priorities after reaching the college.

After she took charge of training, she immediately called on the police commissioner, V. N. Singh, and the Union home minister, L. K. Advani, to apprise them of the serious inadequacies in the training of the police force. One of the glaring deficiencies was the absence of computers and other basic equipment needed for a modern training institution. Yet, amazingly, students were being trained in computers through drawings on blackboards and were even being declared successful! A small store containing outdated books was what constituted the library. There was a serious shortage of law teachers, due to which a single class packed with over 250 students was being conducted by a lone instructor with the help of a microphone and a loudspeaker.

The response of the home minister was spontaneous. He said: 'Bring me proposals and tell me what is required.' Kiran came back excited. She informed the police commissioner about the home minister's response. She and her team of officers quickly got down to work out their proposals. A few days later, she took along single-page proposals for a computer laboratory, firing and driving simulators and multimedia and audio-visual distance learning equipment. The home minister studied